



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with CR

Anonymous (CR)

7th November 2018

Location: QUB

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Sam Manning

CR explained her personal experience of one of the Good Shepherd mother and baby institutions, where she was a resident in 197*. She was 18 years-old at this time and, together with her boyfriend, making plans to go to university. CR was one of a number of interviewees who decided to offer testimony because she wanted to record her positive experience with the Good Shepherd Sisters. She has remained in contact with the nuns since the time she spent with them during her pregnancy. CR recalls a more benign regime than the one described by many other interviewees. For her, the mother and baby home was a safe haven away from the family tensions that ensued when she told her parents about her pregnancy. She described the chores that the pregnant women carried out but maintained that no one was forced to do any work that they did not wish to. CR was more critical of the social worker assigned to her case. She also describes the stigma that was still attached to unmarried mothers in the 1970s and offers testimony on her unpleasant experiences with some staff in the maternity hospital. Initially, CR planned to have her baby adopted. However, this did not happen and she kept the child and married her boyfriend. His support (and that of his mother) were important factors in the decision to keep the baby. CR also explained that the time in the Good Shepherd mother and baby institution allowed her the space in which to reach the decision to keep her child.

To protect CR's anonymity and that of others mentioned in her interview, names, dates and locations are redacted or anonymised wherever practical. A

redaction is indicated by **. CR asked that her baby's gender be anonymised also.

OD: Ok, so just for the purposes of the tape, this is the Northern Ireland Mother and Baby Homes and Magdalene Laundry project office. My name is Olivia Dee. It's 7th November 2018 and I am here with an interviewee, who is going to tell me of her experience. We have had a pre-discussion of some areas that we wish to avoid, so we will be guided by that. So first of all could you maybe tell me about what your connection is to, is it *name redacted*?

CR: *Name redacted: hereafter Good Shepherd mother and baby home*.

OD: *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. Can you tell me what your connection is to that and why you contacted the project?

CR: I was in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home in 197*. *Some details redacted*. I was eighteen-years-old and I was pregnant and I went there to have my baby adopted. So, from everything that happened there and afterwards then, I kept in touch with Sister C out of *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and I have gone to see her every Christmas for the last forty years. I've built up a relationship with her because she looked after me very well. And it was really through visiting her at the Good Shepherd Convent that I got to hear about the project and then they asked ... Sister *name redacted* ... asked me would I be interested in participating and so I said yes I definitely would. So, basically I was in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* from the end of *month redacted* as I said. I had, I was still seeing my boyfriend at the time and it was quite a shock ... I was a naïve Catholic, kind of, wee girl. Got pregnant and at the time both myself and my boyfriend were studying and we had plans to go to

different universities in England. When I found out I was pregnant it was a big shock and we didn't know what to do. And we decided that, it was actually *boyfriend's name redacted* that found out about *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and we decided just to have the baby. And because there was lots of people that didn't have children that we would have the baby and just give it away and that would be ok. And we would go on to university and continue with our studies. So, I had a very difficult relationship with my mother at the time and there was a great sense of shame in me becoming pregnant at eighteen. So this seemed to be the ideal solution. So we went together to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and we were met by Sister T. It was Sister T initially that looked after the home and she explained, you know, how it all worked. So we were happy enough and kind of, I went there then at the end of *month redacted*. And there was a lot of turmoil at home because of my situation. And when I got... and we lived in an area of *location redacted* as well which was very in the thick of the Troubles as well. So there was an awful lot going on and when I got into *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, although my situation was upsetting, it was like going into just this safe haven. Sister T, Sister C who looked after *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, they were like a mummy and daddy who looked after all these girls who got into trouble basically. Sister T was... well I think she was the head or the principal of the home or whatever. But she was a bit, I don't want this to come out the wrong way, but she was a bit more stern. Sister C was lots of fun. They were like an old married couple. They really complemented each other, the two of them. So I just had really good vibes when I went into *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. I just... although the whole situation was upsetting, I thought it was the best thing to do and I was still with my boyfriend *name redacted*, we were very much in love. *Detail redacted*. But *boyfriend's name redacted* still wanted to see me, so he got an hour every Saturday night to see me *detail redacted*. Yeah, so from seven to eight, or eight to nine or something. So,

anyway, as time went on, when I went into *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, I think up until about a month before *baby's name redacted* was born, yeah, we were still of the idea we were going to, still going ahead with university education in England. But as... about six weeks or four weeks before *baby's name* was born, I started thinking this is my baby and I'm going to give [my baby away]. Maybe should I try and keep it and all of that, so especially when you felt the baby moving inside you, so... When I brought that up with *boyfriend's name* on one of his visits, he said to me "thank god for that because I wanted to do the same, but the decision had to come from you". So we started then thinking about keeping the baby, keeping the baby so. But my time... I know this is a study about *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and the care I received in there. It was just second to none. As I say, Sister T really, she looked after the whole business side of the home. The way it worked was that you went in and you were assigned a social worker and whatever way the money worked out, you got an allowance obviously from the government, but that went to pay for your upkeep in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home.* And I always remember it was three pounds something left out of that. And you got three pound back every week and I saved up all those three pounds.

OD: So what did you do with that? Toiletries, what ... or did you save?

CR: *Boyfriend's name*'s [mother was] *redaction* very good. [She] *redaction* visited me every week and brought up a lot of stuff like that, toiletries and things like that. I made the decision when I went into *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* not to go out because we had to try and help my family. My mother was distraught because of how it would be seen in the community. They owned a local business and, to be fair to my mum, she was *detail redacted* she [was] the eldest girl and she didn't get an education and I

was the eldest in my family and she was so happy that I was going to be going off to university. So it was a big thing for her that this had happened. So I wanted still to try and go to university ... I was just beginning to show at the end of *month redacted*. So when I went into *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* we told everybody that ... I had gone to university because I was going to get the baby adopted and then I was going to come back. And then we... my mum phoned the university and ... she said I was sick and they said they would still take me in after Christmas, after the baby was born.

OD: So you would, ah ok, got it.

CR: So that was the plan, that was the plan when I went in. [Not even my younger siblings] knew I was in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. So I decided... this was one of the things you could have done. You went in and you just didn't go out anywhere. So I didn't go out anywhere until *baby's name* was born. So, I was in there with, there was between seven and eight of us altogether. And for me, although it was a difficult time in my life, it was very calm and it was just so the right place to be to help [me] gently make decisions about [my] life. That's the way it was for me. You were given a, I had a single bedroom ... and there was like a large TV/work room where we sat making Irish Colleen dolls for the tourist industry. All these seven or eight pregnant girls sitting doing these. It's so bloody ironic when you think of it. Or cushions... so, I mean, you weren't made to work, to be honest. It was something there gentle for you to put your day in. Like, what else were you going to do, just sit there, you know. *Detail redacted* ... [I]t was a very supportive environment to be in. The rules were, because everybody was getting their baby adopted, the rules were that, you know, you didn't pry into another girl's background because the confidentiality was a big thing. And it was only first-name terms. You didn't say where you were from, or you didn't say your

surname, or anything about your background. But obviously living together with seven other girls for like three to four months, that was very difficult. But there was a great respect there for each other and there was no... whether I was just lucky to be in a group of girls that we did connect well with each other generally. We connected well, we didn't pry into each other's lives, we gave each other space when we needed to. We did talk about whether we were going to have a girl or a boy, whether we were thinking of keeping it or not and I think at the time that I was in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, times were beginning to change, that girls were beginning to feel a bit more confident. If I want to keep this baby, and be a single mother and have a baby, well then I'm bloody well going to do it. And two fingers up to whoever's going to tell me I can't do it. Right, so it was beginning to change a wee bit. There were some girls there who were, you could see they were completely distraught. I don't know enough about all of their backgrounds. I know before I left, and I was just about to give birth, there was one girl came in... I was the youngest, I was eighteen and I think the other girls were kind of like twenty, twenty-two, twenty-three. I know there was one girl, *name redacted*, [who] was forty.

OD: Forty?

CR: Yeah.

OD: And pregnant?

CR: *Detail redacted*. We got on well with the nuns... We did have a good bit of craic, especially making these bloody dolls, you know. I mean, and we were saying about American tourists, I wonder do these American tourists coming in buying these Irish Colleen dolls. Do they know they're made by these pregnant

girls in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*? But there was no, there was never any, you weren't made to work, you know, you absolutely weren't.

OD: Yeah.

CR: And if you had a down day that you had a lot to sort out in your head and if you just wanted to sit in your room, yes you could have done that, but Sister T or Sister C would have been up, gently encouraging you, saying 'what's wrong?', you know, whatever. Sister C was like fabulous ... woman. Really fabulous woman [W]hen I think back, she was, I'm a wee bit older now, she would have been in her fifties when I was there. And I think she existed on about three hours to five hours sleep a night. She... there was other girls, another girl in the home I know had a lot of difficulty with other things beside her pregnancy. She, you know, Troubles related and because all our bedrooms were in a corridor, if someone was up during the night you could hear them. You could hear Sister C then talking to her. You could hear sobbing [indicates continued sobbing] And Sister C would never ever [have], you know ... complained. And she had something wrong with *identifying detail redacted* I thought 'flip me, the energy that woman has' So my time in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* it was kind of, you know, doing the dolls. As well, *detail redacted* there was Sister Y, who was a very old nun, and she was in the kitchen. So I helped her in the kitchen cook the meals. And it was just like a big family home, you know. At times we were asked to clean the windows, yes, and to help with a bit of 'housework' in inverted commas. But it was like living together, it was like chores that you were doing. And you didn't have to do them. Now, when I left *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and had my baby, after I had my baby, I went back in subsequent years to visit Sister T and Sister C after that. Sister T said to me, '*name redacted*', probably her terminology was not right, what she said to me, but she said 'the girls that we're

getting in now, they just want to sit around and smoke. They are so cheeky'. She says 'they won't help out with chores. They're not doing anything'. Those two nuns were having an awful time, right.

OD: How much later was this sorry?

CR: It would have been about, it would have been about into the eighties. I would have said about maybe five or six years after that. And I felt, I really felt for them because from a human being point of view those two nuns could not have done more psychologically, physically, every way to help you. When the social worker that I had coming up to see me, looking back now, she was a trainee social worker and really... I felt I was more mature at eighteen to be honest than, I remember her name was *name redacted*. And she used to come up to me and talk about stupid things that... I mean ... I remember one time she came up and she told me about a sore tooth that she was having when she walked in...

OD: And you were pregnant...

CR: Yes, I know. And she was... so yeah there was ups and downs. And every question I asked her, she could never answer. She had to go back to her senior social worker person and ask and it was always a long... you know, she didn't, and God help her too, she was starting out in her profession or whatever, she was learning. But she didn't do it for me, no so... I don't know if I'm waffling too much here.

OD: No, no, I just wanted to make sure it was definitely recording [checking recording device]. No, this is fantastic, carry on.

CR: So anyway, yeah the social worker, so every kind of step I came to in thinking ‘should I have this baby? Should I keep [the baby]? What am I going to do?’ I would have brought it to Sister T or Sister C. They would have said: “Ask your social worker, ask your social worker.” They never would have got involved in making major decisions. They always put you back to the social worker. But I found her crap, to be honest, a lot of the time. And it wasn’t her fault, it was because she was a trainee social worker and she didn’t have life experience to be able to advise me. And probably Sister T and Sister C didn’t have the life experience either, you know, so. What else? The meals, the meals, good home-cooked food, you know, and Sister T and C treated us like the children that they never had in a way. And maybe some people going in there would have found that patronising, perhaps. Maybe in the late eighties, maybe some girls just thought ‘who do they think they are?’ At the end of the day, they were doing a job. For me, they provided such a safe haven. The months before I went into *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* were not good. The year after [CR became emotional at this point] was terrible. It was awful.

OD: Do you want to talk about that or no, because it’s completely fine to not talk about.

CR: No, because this is about *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*.

OD: Yeah. Was it sad because...

CR: I just want to... It was so safe for me in there and it made everything safe and they made everything just the right way. And it really ... angers me to hear, you know... I know things must have gone on in these Magdalene laundries, but that wasn’t *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* that absolutely wasn’t. And if there’s going to be some girls and women come out to say that I was in

Good Shepherd mother and baby home the same time as me, they are telling lies, they really are, because it wasn't. And Sister C and Sister T ... they were at their wits' end when I went up to see them in the eighties. They didn't know what to do ... And then when the home closed, I don't know when the home closed.

OD: Eighties. Was it mid-eighties?

CR: Was it the nineties? The late eighties? I think maybe eighty-eight, ninety, the home closed. And then so, yeah, the year after was awful. And it was more, it was society's fault, it was society and, you know, even when I went into *maternity hospital* to have my baby, and I was surprised at this, some of the nurses in that hospital. I mean there was definitely a judgemental thing about an eighteen-year-old girl having a baby. There was definitely that in society, and as if like, the jaw dropped, you know for god sake we bloody had sex. *Detail redacted*

OD: Unlucky!

CR: So, I mean, but it was like you were a tramp on the street. When I was in labour and I went into *maternity hospital* ... and I remember going "Jesus Christ!" like that there with one of the labour pains.

OD: Because it hurt?

CR: Yes, because it hurt. And then one of the nurses in *maternity hospital*, she was very brusque and she said: "Now, now, now, we'll be having none of that, we'll be having none of that." And I felt like saying: "You ***** well

aren't having this baby'. [CR and OD laugh] And I was like, and I know I'm cursing, but you know, but it was like, you know...

OD: It's understandable.

CR: And it was from the nurses in the hospital ... And there was a women in the next bed to me and after I'd had the baby then I knew, I mean I couldn't go back to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and that was terribly upsetting for me because I was going back to a lot of difficulty at home and I was crying my eyes out in bed and I remember this [becoming tearful] woman got out of bed and she was a Protestant ... and I had rosary beads, somebody at that time, I don't know how I got the rosary beads. Maybe Sister C put them in my bag or something. And she came up and put, this woman, like she'd just delivered a baby herself [too] and she ... got out of bed and put the rosary beads in my hand. I don't mean to cry.

OD: No, but it's like little bits of kindness, isn't it?

CR: Yes, and the other women were nice and they weren't judgemental. But I didn't like the hospital.

OD: So in *name of maternity hospital redacted* were you in a separate ward, or were you with...

CR: No, I was in the ward with the other ladies. You stayed six days in there then before you got out.

OD: And was there a noticeable difference in the way they treated you?

CR: I felt ... a difference from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* because [there] we were all treated... and there was no judgement. There was no judgement at all. And, you know, the camaraderie between us girls was great. That's what kept us going, you know, it really was great. And sometimes it got too happy, I think. And there was one day there was a wee young priest that came in and I can't remember his name. Was it, was a first name, was it Father *name deleted* or something? And there was a bit of banter with him and a bit of craic. And I remember one day, he decided to take them all out, take everybody out in a minibus, can you imagine? And because I didn't go out ... I obviously didn't go out but all the rest of them went out. And they had a whale of a day. He brought them out somewhere, can you imagine just this wee young priest and like seven pregnant girls... very obviously pregnant right, can you just imagine that? And it was up in the country somewhere. They had an absolute ball and they came back and they were all buzzing. Sister C was not happy, or Sister T, they were not. But it was a hoot, it really was.

OD. And did you not go, was that because you were saving money or because you didn't want people to see you?

CR: Because I didn't want people to see me pregnant *detail redacted*.

OD: It must have been difficult.

CR: *Redaction* I was trying to save my mummy's face as well. I was trying to do too much stuff, and you know it was far too much pressure, too much pressure [for an 18-year old girl].

OD: Huge amount of pressure, yeah.

CR: She was a hard woman [referring to CR's mother].

OD: It must have been, just the web around you and not being able to go out and not being able to...

CR: Not being able to go out, that was kind of ok. That wasn't a difficult thing. It wasn't because I just thought this is what I have to do. So I just kind of, you know but it was what was going to happen after. I worried about that. And I suppose the biggest thing was, you know, *boyfriend* came up and saw me the whole time there and his [mum was] brilliant. My God, I really connected with his mum.

OD: And was his mum ok with...

CR: Oh yeah, she was like salt of the earth *location redacted* woman, no bother at all. And I loved her to bits till the day that she died. And ... you know... she saw what was happening and she was there and only for her, like she was brilliant ... and I was very close to my dad. My dad was a very quiet man.

OD: So your mum was perhaps the one who was more dominant?

CR: Yes, definitely *redaction* and my dad just couldn't... when I said that I was going to keep the baby, he just went 'thank God, thank God', you know, that I wasn't going to...

OD: It's interesting that they both reacted that way, that your partner and your dad both reacted like that.

CR: Yeah, *detail redacted* and ... my dad was just over the moon, over the moon. So yeah, it was really difficult then when I came out.

OD: So there was no way that you could have... because I know in some homes there was a period where you go back to the home afterwards. I know that wasn't the case...

CR: Well actually what happened [after the baby's birth], it's another story ... *detail redacted*.

page redacted

OD: So did you keep [your baby]?

CR: I did keep [the baby], yes.

OD: But [the baby] was sort of shipped around to different places. It must have just been so difficult.

CR: We had to get Christmas over, and the [family] business. And then we just told all the family the truth. We just said we've told lies.

OD: And was it as bad as everyone thought?

CR: Our family, uncles, aunts, people descended on us to help then and that was good.

OD: That is good.

CR: Yeah, that was good and we came through it. But then Mummy still wanted me to go away to university in January and I just said: “No, I want to stay with my baby.” And that was, so it was hard.

OD: So that kind of caused more...

CR: We got Christmas over, yeah, but then she went back to her old self and it was very difficult, but we’re talking about *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* so....

OD: Of course, so in that... Can I ask a couple of questions, but I’ll steer away from [the time] either side of [time spent in]*Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. When you decided to keep *baby’s name*, did you and *boyfriend’s name* stay together in that year?

CR: Yeah, we’ve been together forty years.

OD: Oh wow! Ok, that’s great. Sorry, I didn’t realise.

CR: It’s ok.

OD: I just wanted to know so I could understand...

CR: Yeah, we’re still together. *Detail redacted*

OD: Ok, great. So gives me a sense of that then. Fantastic. When you decided to keep the baby, was there any resistance to that from social workers, from nuns, from members of the... there was no sense that it would be better for you to give it up?

CR: No, absolutely not. Actually, the other way. I [had been] wanting to give [the baby] up ... because it was neat. That was the way my plan, then, could work out.

OD: So you'd be gone by *month redacted* and...

CR: So, to be fair to the social worker, when she ... came back after asking her senior social worker the question, I was coming up with all these scenarios and I would have said, you know, "what about if we got the baby fostered for like six months, a year, two years. And I went and did my education and then I come back and got [the baby]. Would that work?" And she would go "no", and she would say "you're still seeing your boyfriend", she says. She would keep on giving me scenarios, she would say "what if you and your boyfriend then do get married and then you do decide to have children, and you find out you can't have any more children? And the only child you've had, you've given away. How would you feel that way?" So she kept on giving me scenarios...

OD: So she was pushing you to think for yourself?

CR: They could see that I was ... very much in love with my boyfriend. But I was the one giving the baby away and it was only when you can really feel [the baby] inside you that I was going erm ...

OD: You've got a connection.

CR: ... thinking back about when we first went into *Good Shepherd mother and baby* and we were finding out about how everything worked, I do remember thinking, because Sister T was quite business-like, and I remember

her saying something like, “sometimes it’s for the best.” But she was saying it in a gentle way.... She was very professional in what she did, in giving you the information that you needed. That was, my understanding was the ethos of the home, from a Catholic point of view, was that so you didn’t have to have an abortion. Right, so you had the baby and that’s just the way it was done; so she explained that, you know. So there was no pressure put on me to, absolutely not to give the baby up.

OD: It was about providing you a place so you didn’t have to go England and have an abortion? Or was that not even discussed?

CR: Well, it was because... well it was at the beginning. Obviously, the Catholic teaching is you don’t have an abortion. So it’s pro-life. And that would have been my thinking as well, I wouldn’t have had... I mean maybe for a fleeting, but that was probably in a panic. I wouldn’t have had an abortion. So it was like, to my eighteen-year-old self, it was like simple – have a baby and give it away to someone who can’t have a baby. What’s everybody’s problem with it?

OD: And then you realised that you started to feel different?

CR: Yes. And the calmness of *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* allowed me to come to that decision myself. It allowed me to do that myself.

OD: So do you think that if you had been in different circumstances that may have been different? So do you think, for example, say if someone came in and they weren’t in a relationship, and they weren’t stable and they... I know that you didn’t really say that you were stable particularly, but do you think in different circumstances that might have been more inclined to suggest adoption?

CR: Absolutely not. Well, it was whatever the person themselves, whatever the girl wanted. It was whatever the girl wanted. Yes, there were girls there with me that were obviously in difficult situations. We were all in difficult situations, but I didn't know everybody's circumstances. Now we did share personal experiences and I did, as you do, I did become closer with a couple of the girls and I knew more about a couple of the girls than I did know about others. And we didn't know ... it was just not discussed whether you were keeping your baby or not. It was a thing out there that it was nearly like too personal to go in [to] and we just didn't do that because we were... and there was days when we would have gone down into the sewing room and some girls just would have just been in floods, you know, or would have been in a bad place.

OD: Because they didn't know what to do?

CR: Yes, yes.

OD: I'm not surprised.

CR: And because maybe they were, maybe they were... If I hadn't have had *boyfriend's name* coming to see me, if I didn't have the support of him, if I didn't have the support of his mother, I probably would have given *name of baby* up. I probably would have.

OD: Which is really understandable. It must have been terrifying.

CR: I probably would have, really, yeah.

OD: You have that support for a small amount of time, but as you found out, when that support's gone, it becomes harder and more stressful.

CR: Yeah.

OD: And if you don't have that support all the way through it must be so hard.

CR: ... before I left there was one girl called *name redacted* came in and ... I think she was about sixteen. And that wee girl came in absolutely distraught. I remember she was wearing something blue. She had this mop of ginger hair. She was absolute... and I think, I think she had been completely... she was from the south of Ireland and she was completely disowned by her family. And I mean, I as a mother cannot get my head round that, Jesus Christ like.

OD: Sending someone away.

CR: Do you know what I mean? Because they've had sex. For God's sake.

OD: And to another country, technically.

CR: And I remember putting my arm around the wee girl and saying: "Look, you know, you've got my place. I was [the] youngest here before you came here", and all this here and "look, the food's nice and you're looked after well." But it was because of what her family had done to her, not what... and *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* was, like, thank God for it, you know, thank God for it at the time for me.

OD: That's really, really interesting.

Redaction

CR: I remember one Saturday night, [my boyfriend] came up to visit me and the kettle was broke. And he spent an hour fixing the nun's kettle. And he didn't have a visit like, you know.

OD: But he fixed the kettle?

CR: He fixed the kettle, yeah, so.

OD: And you mentioned a bit about not wanting to go out, or not feeling that you should go out.

CR: Yeah.

OD: Were you allowed out whenever you wanted? Or was there, kind of, things you could do? I'm just wondering what the restrictions were.

CR: I wasn't allowing myself out ... *detail redacted*

OD: No, no, of course, but if you had wanted to, you could go whenever you wanted?

CR: Yeah, yeah, because there were times some of the other girls says: "Ach CR, just walk, we'll...'. They would have gone up and down to maybe the Post Office or the shop. They ... said "just walk up there." And I was tempted, but I didn't. I didn't because I thought if [a relation or someone] sees me ...

OD: It would just be too hard.

CR: Yes

OD: And too stressful, I'm sure.

CR: Yes.

OD: Ok, great. So it was things like Post Office or shop?

CR: Yeah, yeah.

OD: Of course. With regard to your names, you kept your own name. You weren't assigned a name?

CR: Yeah, you could have changed your name if you had have wanted to keep your privacy and your confidentiality.

OD: Did you ever recognise anyone?

CR: No ... I didn't know anybody in there. There was a number of girls ... from the country. *redaction* There [were some] from Belfast. *Redaction*

OD: So it wasn't like you were all from the same street?

CR: No, no. I think they were all country. I think there was myself and *name redacted* who were the only girls from *CR's home area* in there.

OD: Good. I always just wonder... but it seems like people from all over the country and from the south.

CR: Yeah.

OD: Did you have any medical checks while you were there? Were Sister C or Sister T were they midwives?

CR: Sister C was a midwife, yeah... And she was quite knowledgeable. And ... A doctor came in for doctor's visits.

OD: So you had a doctor come in and then anything in the interim Sister C could take care of?

CR: Yeah.

OD: So did she have the sort of equipment there to do that with? Or was it just a case of making sure that you felt okay, or looking out for you?

CR: Yeah, she would have felt round your tummy like, felt where the baby was or if you'd any problems, yeah.

OD: And then you were allowed to go out for doctor's visits, so things like...

CR: Yeah, but I didn't go out. The doctor came in.

OD: Oh yeah, of course, yeah, yeah.

CR: ... if, say you were feeling not well or anything, yeah the doctor would be called in.

OD: Even, so even for like, would that be for major things or if you had heartburn or something, could you talk to someone about that? Or would you have just got on with it?

CR: I wasn't, I didn't have any problems, only being pregnant like. But that's not...

OD: Yeah.

CR: You know I didn't ...

OD: You weren't sick?

CR: No, I wasn't. I had a very healthy pregnancy. I had a very quick labour and no problems whatsoever, you know, so, but ...if I have had there wouldn't have been any problems getting the doctor in or getting attention for you.

OD: Were you told what to expect? Did someone explain because I often wonder, you were eighteen?

CR: Yeah.

OD: Did you know what labour was going to be like? Did someone explain that to you, or like waters breaking or things like that? Because I just imagine that must be...

CR: Sister C told us, you know, when [I] think about it.

OD: Was that from sort of a midwife perspective?

CR: Yes. I'm trying to remember now that you say that. She would have had wee talks. And *name redacted: one of the residents* was a nurse and she used to always make fun of what Sister C said because she said she was far too old-fashioned. It doesn't happen like that at all. It happens like this, you know. Just that bit of banter. She would have said: "You learned that forty years ago." But it was good-hearted, you know.

OD: So you went into labour with an idea of, you know, it was going to hurt and this would happen, and a baby would come out.

CR: Yeah ... I was very naïve looking back.

OD: Because just thinking of myself at eighteen, I'm wondering how much I would have known.

CR: I remember ... when the baby was coming ... I was due on *date redacted* or something. [The baby] was born on *date redacted*, so it was like two weeks overdue. So, yeah, I had a show¹ in the toilet at eleven o'clock at night, and I went and I knocked Sister C's door and I told her. Then ...she got the ambulance then right away. And I remember sitting in the back of the ambulance and my knees were shaking like this here [shakes knees]. And I remember saying to the ambulance man: "Is that part of labour that your legs all shake?"

OD: Or am I just terrified?

¹ Mucus. An indicator of the first stages of labour.

CR: And he didn't speak to me. And he just went and got a blanket and put a blanket over my knees. And he just petted me like that.

OD: Because you were cold.

CR: Well I think I was nervous ... you know. And then ...when I got in [to hospital] and there [were] nurses and it was like here's another one of them girls. Now they didn't say that.

OD: But that was implied.

CR: Yeah, that annoyed me. And it was like they looked at you differently and that was bad. It was like bloody medieval times, do you know what I mean?

OD: I was going to say, because it's a vulnerable, really vulnerable time. Did you give birth alone? You didn't have family members or anything.

CR: No, on my own. Yes.

OD: Would you have been able to have, like if you'd wanted, would your mum have done that, or...

CR: No way. No way.

OD: Was there anyone you would have like to have asked?

CR: Do you see the whole [thing] about birthing plans and all: I'm a granny now, and like it's too much over the top. It's too much information. I mean, we

didn't have a birthing plan, you didn't have any of that stuff in those days. None of that.

OD: Not even something someone there to just help like *boyfriend's name*. Would he have come?

CR: Because of the situation, no. No, it wasn't discussed, it wasn't.

OD: Do you think it was harder then, being alone? Only because, like you say...

CR: I don't know.

Redaction

OD: But I just wondered if having someone there would have made it less...

CR: I was frightened, there's no doubt about it. I was frightened. When I look back on it, I was frightened, yeah.

OD: Were you given any pain relief? Did you have an epidural?

CR: I don't think so. I don't think so.

OD: Wow.

CR: No, not an epidural. That's the injection, no, no. Gas, I had gas and air. But I just wanted it all to be over. I remember thinking...

OD: How long were you in labour for?

CR: How long? It was only from eleven o'clock that night and [the baby] was born at six o'clock the next morning.

OD: Wow. Seven hours. It's better than a lot.

CR: Yeah, you see from a physiological point of view I think a young girl or a young woman's body does... that's what they say in these kind of Indian tribes and all, that a younger female body gives birth easier than an older body.

OD: Still, seven hours at eighteen must have felt quite long.

CR: Yeah, and I remember them taking me into the delivery and when that nurse said... and I just thought, I thought nurses were supposed to be nice, like, you know, she was horrible, she was. And there was a couple of them just...

OD: So you said something, you said, you know, I remember you said something about Jesus Christ. It hurt so much.

CR: Jesus Christ, I was going.

OD: And they shut that down?

CR: And she just says, her exact words were: "Now that's enough of that now, that's enough of that now."

OD: But they weren't nuns were they, they were just nurses?

CR: Yeah.

OD: Because I know there's some overlap sometimes.

CR: But what I'm saying to you ... it was society. There was stuff put there in society about these 'dirty wee girls' having these babies, in [the 1970s]. And I mean ... you know, my mum picked up on that and she should have been stronger. But yeah...

OD: But when it's coming from everywhere and when you're religious and your religion says that....

CR: ... it wasn't like that in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. ...and that is why I kept up [returning to visit the nuns there], because when somebody is good to you and ... that was a very, very hard time of my life. *Redaction*. So we would have brought *name of baby* back then the following Christmas [the nuns wanted me to come back to see them after I left]. And then the following Christmas we got married, and then the following Christmas we had another baby. So there was always news to tell them. And then it just got tradition. And then Sister T died and Sister C was distraught and the two of them were like a wee married couple, they really were, the way they looked after them girls. And ... my heart just goes out to them for anybody coming out and telling lies or saying things that didn't happen. *Redaction* ... I've heard things in the media. [If there was any fault in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home's system you could criticise it was] the way the [financial] system was set up ... [was] that you got dole money The way the system should have worked should have been, I suppose, that I got that benefit directly to me and I paid the home for my care [*note added by CR* - Basically you were entitled to benefits].

OD: But, instead, you paid it to them and then they paid you?

CR: No, the money went directly to them and then they gave you the change. Yes, the system probably wasn't right, but I'm sure that wasn't Sister T or Sister C's fault. It's the way the system was set up and they didn't do it with any malice, but if anybody's going to find fault with anything then maybe [that] could have been improved on. But it wasn't a big thing. It wasn't anything that anybody complained about while I was there.

OD: And I suppose you, if you hadn't have got that to pay for it, then you would have had to find another way to pay to stay there. I mean, did your parents have to give any money or anything?

CR: No ...

OD: Ok, that's interesting. This is a really interesting story. And I'm really happy and glad that you've told it. And I've asked kind of the things that I pointed out, so I suppose I just wondered, did you have anything else that you wanted to kind of bring up. Because we don't want to go too far away from your experience in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* Although I do think your experience in *maternity hospital* is also really interesting.

CR: I'll show you this.

OD: Ok, go ahead.

CR: This is something I've kept [brings out document]

OD: Is this alright on the tape?

CR: This is from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, yeah.

OD: Oh wow!

CR: This is a poem before I left, because there was such good camaraderie between us all, and *name redacted* wrote this, one of the other girls, she wrote this and gave us all a copy of it ... And if you want I'll read it out on the tape.

OD: That would be great.

CR: So this is...

OD: Sorry, before you do, can I just say this is for the purposes of the tape, this is a very well-preserved, but also clearly old, letter written on just kind of like blue letter paper.

CR: Yeah.

OD: Completely cellotaped together.

CR: Well I put the cellotape on...

OD: In order to keep it....

CR: Yeah, that was the days before, what do you call it?

OD: So you can kind of wrap it: laminate it.

CR: Laminate it, yeah. Laminated it with cellotape.

OD: Wow, it's clearly been preserved. Please go ahead.

CR: So there was great craic between all of us girls and this poem just sums it up. And it's 'Bye for now!?', by *initials redacted*.

[CR reads poem aloud]

Well I never thought I'd see the day,
when I'd finally be on my way.
But I'll always think and I'll always pray,
that we'll maybe BUMP into each other someday.
When we all were together we had laughs and fun,
and we told each other it would be a girl or a son
A special bye to *name redacted*, who really was great craic,
and I liked her because she was matter of fact
Goodbye to *name redacted*, a great girl to know,
her niceness and charm hit me first with a blow
Farewell to *name redacted*, whose voice is so high,
and I hope things work out for her and her guy
Finally cheers to our *name redacted*, who is really a laugh,
but one thing about *name redacted*, she never was soft
So I hope everything works out fine,
because it has for me all along the line
Goodbye for now and I'm sure you'll agree,
That we'll all see each other again someday, you'll see.

I don't know what *writer of the poem* did with her baby.

Section redacted

CR:I think about all the girls I was in there with and I don't know how many of them gave up [their babies]. But from a *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* point of view there was no pressure at all. It was what you wanted yourself.

OD: And you kept yours and you had another baby.

CR: Yes, *name of first child*. And then we had another *name of second child*.

OD: So you've got two children?

CR: Yes.

OD: And grandchildren?

CR: ... Yes, aha.

OD: That's lovely.

Redaction

CR: We've a good life. I mean, things haven't been perfect, but we've had a good life together. We've really enjoyed it, and I think that the whole experience has made us a lot stronger to be honest.

OD: I think having the guy stay around for that is really interesting and, I don't know, it's very touching in a way that you went through that together and that he speaks like you do.

CR: He hated me being there. He hated it. And we wrote to each other, which strengthened the relationship because there was no mobile phones then. We didn't even phone each other up, we wrote letters.

OD: I think that's a really interesting story. Is there anything else you'd like to say?

CR: No.

OD: That was a really lovely way to end it if you're happy...

Redaction

OD: Well, that's lovely. If you're happy then I'll switch off the tape, unless there's anything else.

CR: No, unless there's anything else you want to ask me.

OD: I wrote down everything and like I said, I didn't really want to pry either side, so I think we've got a really good covering of your experience in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. I'll switch off the recording.

[END OF INTERVIEW]